

Episode 151: Long Ago... 90 1995 Part 10 Visiting the Original Creator's Workplace in May

Yesterday, January 10th, was "Coming of Age Day." Due to the legal revision called "Happy Monday" in 1999, Coming of Age Day, which had been January 15th every year, became the second Monday of January - it's been quite a while now. Originally, why was January 15th Coming of Age Day? Because traditionally this January 15th was called "Koshogatsu" (Little New Year), and it was customary to perform coming-of-age ceremonies on this day - rituals where society recognises boys as adults. Why do they carelessly change holidays with such origins? Here's a middle-aged man who feels great resentment toward holiday laws and legal systems that disregard such ancient cultural customs.

Well, anyway, Coming of Age Day. In Tokyo's Nakano Ward where I live, and many municipalities nationwide, ceremonies and events called coming-of-age ceremonies are held on this Coming of Age Day. Recently, there are many idiots who cause trouble during these ceremonies. How long are you going to remain children! this old man wants to say. I think all such people should be arrested!

And some municipalities hold such coming-of-age ceremonies at places like "Toshimaen" or "Disneyland." This is completely incomprehensible to me. Because isn't a coming-of-age ceremony supposed to be "from today you join the ranks of adults"? So why "return to being children and enjoy the day"? Just because such places happen to exist locally? That's thoughtless. They're not thinking about anything at all.

So every year when this "Coming of Age Day" comes around, I get inexplicably irritated. Anyway.

One Sunday afternoon in May after Golden Week ended, we gathered in front of a certain station a bit past where the Odakyu Line crosses the Tamagawa River. "We" being Series Director Umezawa-san, Art Directors Yuki Yukie-san and Gyoshin Mitsu-

san, and myself. Hmm? Oh, Producer Seki-san arrived quite late to the meeting time (laugh). And our destination was the workplace/home of *Neighbourhood Story* original creator Yazawa Ai-sensei. Under calm, beautiful weather, about a 10-minute walk from the station? An emotional manga artist workplace visit.

The purpose of this workplace visit was "what are manga artists' workplaces like?" The protagonist Mikako's mother in *Neighbourhood Story* is a successful manga artist with a workplace at home where she's always chased by deadlines. Naturally, this visual is drawn in the original manga, but to make it into animation, we need to grasp the overall picture and turn it into settings. What kind of atmosphere is it? What art supplies and pens are placed how? How do they actually draw? So if we could see the real thing, nothing could be better.

And the reason I joined along with the art staff was that since I was entrusted with the overall work colours, "let's see anything that might be relevant." Anyway, I probably didn't understand *Neighbourhood Story*'s world very well myself - where exactly does that taste lurk? Maybe that taste exists in original creator Yazawa-sensei's workplace too. That's what I was thinking.

First, tea in the reception room? and some chat. Then "shall we look? (laugh)" and to the next room. A work room tour.

"Ooh! This is where she draws!" That was my biggest impression above all (laugh). Really, my first manga artist's work room ever. Not just manga artists - seeing the desks and desk areas of working people is enjoyable, right? Yazawa-sensei's desk area also had various art supplies and materials scattered about, but somehow had a "production site aura" that was sparkingly beautiful. And "ah, it's just like in the manga (laugh)."

Nowadays we probably would have taken digital camera photos, but that was still the film camera era. And there was definitely an atmosphere of "you shouldn't ask to photograph a manga teacher's work room" (laugh). Well, maybe Gyo-san and others took

photos? Anyway, we thoroughly observed the room and asked questions about various things that caught our attention.

And we were also shown another room of interest next door. That's right, the digital room. Here too, Macintosh computers shone brilliantly. I think there were about two. The soft white cases unique to Macintosh computers of that era, and matching white-cased monitors, scanners, printers, etc. The transparent digital image processing used in Yazawa-sensei's work title pages and decisive pages and panels - it was born in this room. I was moved by the teacher's hand-drawn (analogue) workplace, but personally, this side gave me more of a "I've been had!" feeling.

Now my home work room has become like a digital fortress secret base with computers and multiple monitors, but back then, I'd never seen a scene with so many computers and peripheral devices lined up throughout an ordinary house room. This was quite a culture shock - ah, from now on, such digital environments will increasingly enter the worlds of manga and our anime, I felt strongly.

And through promotional still work for *Neighbourhood Story*, I would start using computers extensively.

(11.01.11)